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2 April 2024

UW-Madison English Department
600 North Park Street
Madison, WI 53706

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to endorse Dr. Ellen Cecil-Lemkin for the post of Assistant Teaching Professor. My sessions with Dr. Cecil-Lemkin have been a bright spot for me for the past three and a half years, for many reasons. Dr. Cecil-Lemkin's work with me shows her excellence in teaching, infusing disability awareness, instilling confidence in students, and commitment to student success. Here are just a few of my examples.

I have been working with Dr. Cecil-Lemkin since the fall of 2021, when I was taking prerequisites for a master's in counseling. She provided constructive feedback on my application CV and statement of purpose, and I was accepted to the master's program of my choice here at UW. We have continued to work together throughout my program, and my writing has benefited from her support, as evidenced by positive feedback from instructors on my written assignments. Just as importantly, I feel that I have grown in my ability to break down and tackle complex projects, such as clinical case notes, thanks to Dr. Cecil-Lemkin's coaching. Many skills I learned from Dr. Cecil-Lemkin, like setting timers, limiting paragraph length, and focusing on strategic details, have helped me keep my notes succinct and my writing efficient. These long-term contributions to my learning will continue to benefit me far into my future career.

Some of the success of Dr. Cecil-Lemkin's approach comes from the way she infuses disability justice in our work together. Her expertise on inclusive design represents both a deep fund of knowledge and a deep compassion for students with disabilities. As a student with late-diagnosed ADHD, having a writing tutor who understands the role of disability in the writing process has been invaluable to me. For example, when I feel frustrated or overwhelmed with a project and emotions spill out, she listens and provides nonjudgmental acceptance. She has helped normalize some of my struggles and, far from minimizing them, made me feel validated. Additionally, she has provided practical strategies for getting things done. With listening and reflection skills, she has helped me refine my paper topics and reminded me to avoid "scope creep," limiting the amount of material I get sidetracked into and the amount of time spent on research.

Perhaps most life-changingly, she introduced me to Zotero for managing journal articles. My research has never been more organized.

In addition to increased self-efficacy in research, my confidence in my writing process and personal voice has increased since working with Dr. Cecil-Lemkin. I have been able to share some of my most personal writing with her, such as the statement of purpose for my graduate school application. Vulnerability is an uncomfortable but inevitable part of the writing process. Dr. Cecil-Lemkin sat with me through many uncomfortable moments as I worked to bring my ideas to the page and later as I cut beloved sentences. It was her suggestion to create a document of deleted phrases for later use, and her suggestion to mine that document for use in current work. This reaffirms the worth of those words and allows me to keep moving forward. Dr. Cecil-Lemkin supports students in such a way that they can bring vulnerability and creativity to sessions and leave with their ideas more refined and organized than before. This support helped me see that my work was not wasted, that I could write in small bursts and still make progress, leading to reduced stress and lowered task initiation barriers.

Finally, in her commitment to student success, Dr. Cecil-Lemkin goes above and beyond for students, offering flexibility, accommodations, and services. She helps me with focus when I am distracted during session, providing “body doubling” as a strategy for keeping on task, as well as gentle focus reminders when I go on a tangent, one of my main writing challenges. She was responsive when I had to pivot to Zoom meetings due to a broken ankle, and she checked in on what I was working on to ensure accountability on my writing goals. When I took a semester off for mental health reasons but wanted to continue working with her, she consulted with her supervisor and arranged to meet with me monthly for continuity of Writing Center services. Dr. Cecil-Lemkin also referred me in advance to another Writing Center instructor when she would not be available so that I would have access to services during my summer coursework.

All told, these contributions have increased my confidence in both my writing ability and my ability to manage tasks and time. Dr. Cecil-Lemkin’s unique skillset is incomparable and invaluable, and I believe her skills with students like me will translate into exceptional work as an Assistant Teaching Professor. I wholeheartedly recommend her for this position.

Sincerely,

Laura Stoesz, B.A. 2009 (English)
M.S. Candidate 2024
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